



P16 · 30 SCRIPTS, FOR THE ADULT

The Tantrum-in-the-Moment Scripts

Thirty short scripts the adult says out loud during a meltdown, when your own brain is offline. Body-first, not advice-first. Designed to be said in six seconds or fewer. Pairs with the Toddler Big Feelings Cards, which are for the after.

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

Most “what to say to your tantruming child” advice is a three-sentence framework that assumes your brain is online. It is not. The child’s brain is offline. The grocery store is watching. Your own jaw is doing the thing where it locks slightly.

These scripts are designed to be said in six seconds or fewer, by a person whose own nervous system is partly in the meltdown. They are not the most enlightened thing you could say. They are the thing you can actually say.

They do not require you to remember a framework. They do not require you to crouch down to their eye level (you can, when you can). They do not require a quiet room. They work on a sidewalk, in the back seat, in a Target parking lot, in front of your in-laws, at the moment your own patience has just left.

You will say these out loud, even when it feels strange. Saying them out loud does two things: it tells the child their state is being witnessed (which is most of what they need), and it pulls a small piece of your own prefrontal cortex back online (which is what you need).

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This is a parenting companion, not a substitute for child mental health care. If your child has prolonged or severe difficulty regulating, sleep disturbances tied to mood, or any signs of self-harm, please see a pediatric provider.

What this deck is, and is not

IS

- Thirty short scripts for the adult, in the moment.
- A small "what not to say" page.
- A self-repair page for after.
- Printable as cards. Carry-able in a bag.

IS NOT

- A discipline tool. These scripts do not stop a tantrum on a stopwatch.
- A guarantee. Some tantrums end at minute two. Some end at minute thirty. The scripts are for both.
- A philosophy. There is no "method" here. There is "what to say."
- A substitute for repair. Repair happens after. There are cards for that too.

How to use these scripts

- Print on cardstock. Cut along the lines. About the size of a playing card.
- Punch a hole in one corner. Put them on a ring. Keep them in the diaper bag, in the glove box, in your back pocket.
- Read the scripts on a calm day, sitting on the couch, out loud to nobody. Say them three times each. The body starts to recognize them.
- Use them in the actual moment, even if you feel weird at first. Especially if you feel weird at first.

For the screaming, ten scripts

Use when the child is yelling, crying loudly, or making the high-pitched sound you have only heard since you became a parent.

1.

"I see you. I'm right here. You don't have to be quiet yet."

2.

"This is a big feeling. I know. I'm not going anywhere."

3.

"You can be loud. I will not leave."

4.

"I'm not going to fix it. I'm going to be here."

5.

"I know. I know. I know."

(Three times. Slow. Lower your voice each time. The lower your voice goes, the more theirs follows, eventually.)

6.

"My body is calm. My body can hold this."

(This one is for you, said out loud so you believe it. The child hears it as steadiness.)

7.

"I love you when you're like this. I love you when you're not."

8.

"You can cry. You can be mad. We can do this together."

9.

"You don't have to use words yet. The words can wait."

10.

"I'm here. I'm here. I'm here."

For the hitting, kicking, throwing, ten scripts

Use when the body has joined the meltdown. The principle here is body-first: you redirect the body before you address the why. The body cannot hear "why" yet.

11.

"I'm going to hold your hands so they stay soft."

(Then do it. Gentle, not restrictive. Two hands, fingers laced, lowered to the lap. Hold for ten seconds.)

12.

"Feet are for walking and stomping. Not for kicking me."

13.

"You can push this pillow. You cannot push me."

(Hand a pillow over. If you don't have one, a folded jacket works.)

14.

"I'm moving us away from the (lamp / wall / sibling). I will come right back."

15.

"It's okay to be angry. It is not okay to hurt. We can do both."

16.

"I'm going to put this down. We can pick it up when you're back."

(For when they are throwing things. Pick up the thing. Set it out of reach. No lecture.)

17.

"Your hands are strong. Squeeze mine."

(Hold your own hands palm up. Let them squeeze. Strong hands have somewhere to go.)

18.

"I'm not scared of your feelings. I am here."

19.

"That was a hit. We don't hit. I'll move back. I am still here."

(Move slightly back, an arm's length. Stay in the room.)

20.

"You can stomp. Stomp ten times. I'll count with you."

(Count out loud. The counting does it.)

For the going-limp, refusing, ten scripts

Use when the child has gone floppy, stopped responding, hidden under the table, or said "no" twenty times to everything you suggest. This is also a meltdown, just a quiet one.

21.

"I'm not going to leave you. We can stay here as long as you need."

22.

"You don't have to talk. I'll talk a little, and you can listen."

23.

"I'm right here. I will wait."

24.

"You can hide. I can see your feet. You're safe."

25.

"I'm going to count to ten, slowly, and then we'll see what's next."

(Count slowly. If at ten they are still in it, count to ten again.)

26.

"I'm not going to make you. I'm going to wait with you."

27.

"It's okay to be tired. It's okay to be done. I'm here for the done part too."

28.

"I'm sitting down right here. Come find me when you can."

(Sit down. Often, after a minute or two, they crawl over.)

29.

"You don't have to do it now. We can do it together in a minute."

30.

"You are not in trouble. You are not in trouble. You are not in trouble."

(Three times. Slow. The repetition matters. Many quiet meltdowns are about a perceived loss of safety. This script restores it.)

What NOT to say

The four sentences that almost always escalate, in case you want to know what they are so you can hear yourself almost-say them.

“Calm down.”

This is the sentence that taught most of us, growing up, that our feelings were inconvenient. It does not calm anyone. It tells them the feeling itself is the problem.

A substitute: “This is a big feeling. I’m here.”

“You’re fine.”

The child is not fine. The child is in the middle of a feeling. “You’re fine” tells them their reality is wrong. They will then have to work harder to prove they are not fine, which makes the tantrum worse.

A substitute: “You’re having a hard time. I see it.”

“Stop crying.”

The body cannot stop crying on command. Telling it to is asking the impossible.

A substitute: “You can cry. I will be here when you’re done.”

“If you don’t stop, we’re leaving.”

This threat almost never works the way the adult hopes. It either escalates (because the child is not capable of stopping just because there is now a consequence) or it backs you into actually leaving the wedding / park / store, which becomes a story that gets retold for ten years.

A substitute: "This is a lot. I'm going to step outside with you for a minute. We can come back when you're ready."

(Then do it. Walk outside. Come back.)

For the adult, after

The storm has passed. The child is back in their body. Now your nervous system is the one running. These are scripts for you.

“What just happened was a lot.”

Say it out loud, to yourself. Not “the child was a lot.” “What just happened” was a lot. Both of you went through it.

“I’m allowed to need a minute.”

Take it. Wash your face. Sit on the bathroom floor. Two minutes is enough.

“I did the best I could with the brain I had online.”

Even if you said one of the sentences from the “what not to say” page. Even if you raised your voice. The repair is more important than the perfection.

The repair script, for the child

When the child is back, sometime in the next hour or before bedtime:

“Earlier, when you were really upset, I lost a little bit of my calm too. I’m sorry I (raised my voice / pulled you by the arm / said ‘you’re fine’). I love you. I’m still your grown-up. We can keep practicing this.”

Children do not need a perfect parent. They need a parent who repairs. The repair is the work. The repair is also free.

A small framing for the months ahead

If you are reading this in a quiet moment, here is what I want you to know about toddler tantrums. None of this changes what to say in the moment. It might change what you carry to bed at night.

One.

A tantrum is not the child manipulating you. It is the child's nervous system overflowing. Toddlers do not have the cognitive scaffolding to manipulate. They have the cognitive scaffolding to feel things twice as big as the room.

Two.

The prefrontal cortex (the part that handles "self-regulation") is not built yet. It is being built right now, by experiences like the one you just had. You losing your temper does not undo the build. You repairing afterward is part of the build.

Three.

You are not failing. The week of three tantrums a day is a phase. The week of one tantrum a day is also a phase. The week of zero is also a phase. None of them is forever. None of them is a referendum on you.

Four.

The child who has language for their feelings learned the language from someone. That someone is, in most cases, you. Even when you mostly feel like you are surviving.

A note for the kid, when they're older

If, in five years, your kid finds this deck and reads it, what they will read is: the adult was paying attention. The adult was trying. The adult was saying things on purpose, even in the hard moments.

That is a memory worth giving them.

Numbers to keep (for the parent)

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRIC THERAPIST (if any)

Name: _____ Number: _____

SCHOOL COUNSELOR (if any)

Name: _____ Number: _____

US PARENT STRESS LINE

1-800-422-4453 (Childhelp, 24/7, confidential)

US SUICIDE & CRISIS LIFELINE

988 (call or text, 24/7)



From [Soothemade Notes](#), a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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